# Ancient Bird With Dinosaur Teeth May Have Lost the Power to Fly

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A crow-sized fossil found in China is changing the story of how birds evolved. The 150-million-year-old creature, named Yuezhuornis yangyuanensis, lived in the Late Jurassic period, about 150 to 148 million years ago. Researchers say it may be the earliest known bird **lineage** to lose the ability to fly.

That is a surprise. Many people picture early birds steadily becoming better flyers. This fossil suggests early birds were already trying out different ways of life, including life on the ground.

The fossil was found in the Zhenghe Fauna of Fujian Province in southeastern China. Yuezhuornis mixes bird and dinosaur features. It had bird-like pelvic and **hindlimb** structures, but its jaws held closely spaced, **serrated** teeth like those of **deinonychosaurs**, small meat-eating dinosaurs related to birds. Its second toe could bend backward unusually far and carried a curved, sickle-shaped claw.

Scientists compared its anatomy in two ways, maximum parsimony and Bayesian tip-dating. Both put Yuezhuornis within **Avialae**, the group that includes modern birds and their closest extinct relatives, just beyond Archaeopteryx and as a close relative of Zhengheornis. Its limb proportions resembled modern ground-dwelling birds, suggesting it lived on the ground and was likely unable to fly.

## Word Treasure

**lineage** -- A lineage is a family line of living things over a very long time.

**serrated** -- Serrated means having small sharp points along an edge, like a saw.

**hindlimb** -- A hindlimb is a back leg of an animal.

**Avialae** -- Avialae is the group that includes modern birds and their closest extinct relatives.

**deinonychosaurs** -- Deinonychosaurs were small meat-eating dinosaurs related to birds.

## Background you need

Birds evolved from small meat-eating dinosaurs over a very long time.

Early birds did not all become better and better flyers; some tried living on the ground instead.

Fossils like this one help scientists see how different kinds of early birds lived.

## Break it down

**WHO:** Researchers studying the fossil of Yuezhuornis yangyuanensis.
**WHAT:** They found an ancient bird-like creature that may have lost the ability to fly.
**WHERE:** The Zhenghe Fauna of Fujian Province in southeastern China.
**WHY:** Its ground-dwelling body shows early birds tried different ways of life, not just flying.

## Why it matters

It shows that evolution is full of surprises, and even animals you think you know can change in unexpected ways.

## Test what you remember

**1. What is Yuezhuornis yangyuanensis?**

- (A) An ancient bird-like creature
- (B) A baby dinosaur
- (C) A kind of fish
- (D) A modern crow

**2. Where was the fossil found?**

- (A) In the Zhenghe Fauna of Fujian Province in southeastern China
- (B) In Australia
- (C) In North America
- (D) In Africa

**3. What did its jaws hold?**

- (A) Poison fangs
- (B) A long beak with no teeth
- (C) Closely spaced, serrated teeth
- (D) Flat grinding teeth

**4. What did its second toe carry?**

- (A) A feather
- (B) A webbed foot
- (C) A curved, sickle-shaped claw
- (D) A small wing

**5. What did its limb proportions suggest?**

- (A) It swam in the sea
- (B) It climbed tall trees
- (C) It flew faster than other birds
- (D) It lived on the ground and was likely unable to fly

**6. How did scientists compare its anatomy?**

- (A) With maximum parsimony and Bayesian tip-dating
- (B) By counting its bones only
- (C) By painting pictures
- (D) By asking farmers

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: A 3: C 4: C 5: D 6: A

# Questions to think about

**1. Researchers: Yuezhuornis may be the earliest known bird lineage to lose the ability to fly.**

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):